

Concerto legacy

Although Vivaldi set great store by his operas, they are now little known and his reputation rests mainly on his concertos. They are full of exuberant, inventive music and notable for the three-movement pattern that Vivaldi established and that was copied by countless others: a slow, lyrical middle movement between two much quicker ones—the first one typically majestic and the third more playful. The Four Seasons is also one of the earliest and greatest examples of program music—that is, music expressing a narrative or pictorial idea: barking dogs, rustic bagpipes, and icy landscapes are among the vivid images that Vivaldi conjures.